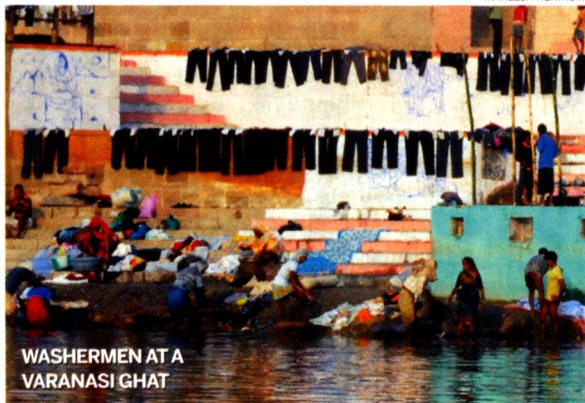


VARANASI | Cleansing Process

The Ganga has been given a new breath of fresh air. Or at least that's the plan. To save the river from further pollution, the city administration has clamped prohibitory orders on both banks of the Ganga under Section 144 of the CRPC. District Magistrate A.K. Upadhyaya says no one can use the banks "as dhobi ghats, to throw corpses and garbage or use soap while bathing". The Ganga is dotted with 80 bathing ghats in the city which were used precisely for those purposes. About 1,400 small-scale units discharge vast quantities of untreated affluent containing lead, cadmium, chromium and nickel into the river. More than 33,000 corpses—burnt or half burnt—are thrown into its waters



each year, accounting for 300 tonnes of burnt flesh. The cremations require 16,000 tonnes of wood which results in 600 tonnes of ash. Also, 6,000 animal carcasses rot in the river in which over 1.5 lakh people bathe each day to wash away their "sins". The local police are to enforce the order. Fulfilling that duty is now the issue.

by Farzand Ahmed

BANGALORE |

Old Rush

A committee of the Karnataka Assembly has tabled a report in the House seeking to reopen the old HAL airport in the heart of Bangalore. Referring to the Bangalore International Airport that opened in May 2008, the 21-member panel also noted that a "flawed policy has allowed the private participant to aim for short-term profit at the cost of the public". A former chief secretary of the state has also filed a petition in the high court saying there is enough traffic to keep both airports running.

by Stephen David

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